

Maintenance of code

Software maintenance is complex and challenging, as it is the longest phase in the software development life cycle. Having discussed differences in JavaScript engines, writing a maintainable code in JavaScript has become even more challenging than an object-oriented language. Easier maintenance of code will help in saving lots of time. Let's discuss a common mistake that we often commit: the structure of the page is mixed with its behaviour. Consider the following code snippet:

```
<html>
<head>
  <script>
    function showMessage () {
    }
  </script>
</head>
<body>
  <div id='details_div' onclick='showMessage()'>Click Me</div>
</body>
</html>
```

In the above case, the presentation (HTML) gets mingled with the behaviour (what gets called when the user clicks the element). We need to separate the presentation from its behavior for better maintainability.

Tougher implementation of rich user interfaces

Though it is possible to create a rich user interface using plain JavaScript, the approach is tougher for beginners and unproductive for development teams. The latter should first work on getting the infrastructure ready and then build their application functionality on top of the infrastructure. But JavaScript libraries help us to write much cleaner code, focusing on solving our problem by giving us the necessary infrastructure. For example, in most JavaScript libraries, features like animation, accessing DOM and special effects have become quite common.

JavaScript libraries

The world is full of problems, and so is software development. Have you ever wondered how so many Web 2.0 applications like WordPress, Orkut and Facebook

ID	Name	Age	Location	Phone
1	Ram	20	Delhi	123566
2	John	21	Chennai	129909234
3	Rahim	30	Mumbai	89345

Figure 1: An example of an HTML table with zebra stripes

were developed? Software development is indebted to the Open Source community for providing world-class libraries, and JavaScript is no exception.

Over the past years, many companies and even individuals have released sophisticated JavaScript libraries. These, by and large, help us to overcome many challenges. Some of the noteworthy JavaScript libraries are GWT, EXTJS, Yahoo, Prototype, DOJO, Open Rico, Mootools and JQuery. Like IDEs such as Eclipse and NetBeans, these libraries have tremendously improved the productivity of developers.

Out of the JavaScript libraries available, JQuery is supposed to be simple, fast and lightweight. This article provides a higher-level overview of JQuery, its features and how to integrate JQuery with Web applications. Towards the end, we will discuss a simple example that covers the basic usage of JQuery. In the coming months, we will also discuss each of the important features of JQuery in detail.

JQuery: An introduction

JQuery is arguably the fastest, most concise and elegant JavaScript framework with support for flexible selectors, CSS3, object detection, method chaining, AJAX, plug-ins and UI effects. It is an open source JavaScript library that simplifies the interaction between HTML and JavaScript. Way back in January 2006, John Resig, the creator of JQuery, announced its first public version.

JQuery is named so to indicate its vibrant ability to 'query' any DOM element from any page. The complete library is written in pure JavaScript. The latest version shows improvements in selection performance compared to older versions. JQuery is designed to change the way we write JavaScript—to write less, and do more. As mentioned earlier, the footprint of JQuery is very small—an uncompressed version of JQuery is 120 KB and a minimised version is about 19 KB in size.

There are innumerable plug-ins available for JQuery.

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